seemed to dangle in midair for several moments before plummeting to the ground. As I returned to the huddle, he limped off the field while Mac tried to suppress a cough. The next Saturday, I was in the starting lineup and averaged all but two minutes of every game for the remainder of the season and the two seasons that followed it. I owe Mac a lot; he didn't dislike me after all; he just saw some things in an eighteen-year-old kid that needed some correcting.

On one of our out-of-town trips, the team had to stay overnight in Dixon; Mac said I had to stay at the hotel with the rest of the team and so I went with him to a downtown hotel to help us register. The hotel manager said: "I can take everybody but your two colored boys."

"Then, we'll go someplace else," Mac said.

"No hotel in Dixon is going to take colored boys," the manager shot back.

Mac bristled and said all of us would sleep on the bus that night. Then I suggested another solution: "Mac, why don't you tell those two fellows there isn't enough room in the hotel for everybody so we'll have to break up the team; then put me and them in a cab and send us to my house."

Mac gave me a funny look; he'd just had a chance to observe firsthand what the people of Dixon thought of blacks, and I'm sure he had his doubts my parents would think much of the idea. "You're sure you want to do that?" he asked.

I knew my parents well and said yes. We went to my house and I rang the bell and Nelle came to the door and I told her there wasn't enough room for the whole team at the hotel. "Well, come on in," she said, her eyes brightening with a warmth felt by all three of us.

She was absolutely color blind when it came to racial matters; these fellows were just two of my friends. That was the way she and Jack had always raised my brother and me.

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